ensuing concern contributed thereafter to the hardening of positions on the border issue. Since then, the protagonists have seen an endurance that they may not have expected of the other.

The complicating impact of domestic politics on the relationship was obviously not restricted to the Chinese side. In India too, diplomatic options became increasingly constricted as public and political passions rose higher. Today's generation would be surprised at the extent to which they constrained decision-making in the run-up to the conflict. A look back at the 1960 visit of Premier Zhou Enlai is particularly instructive.

The other big issue that shapes the narrative of this period is China's relationship with Pakistan. The origins of this friendship are worth revisiting, because an understanding of the past provides insights to its future. An authoritative account* of these ties asks why a relationship that otherwise lacks a bond of cultural affinity or common values – normally the basis for alliances – has outlasted the test of time and global changes. Its answer is worth reflecting on. China obviously is essential for Pakistan to address a power imbalance in relation to India, especially after Western powers showed declining enthusiasm for that goal. And Pakistan, in turn, is useful for China as it transitions from being a regional power to a global one. It not only helps keep India within the South Asia box but also provides a pathway to the Islamic world. As time passed, new reasons kept emerging that gave these ties further contemporary relevance. Shared interests in the Afghan theatre was one and maritime ambitions another.

If India did not see this coming when it first did, it could only be in allowing the first principles of balance of power to be clouded by nobler goals of a better world. It is worth recalling that these ties warmed up even as the 1962 border conflict with India loomed. Once they did, it took full advantage of the contiguity that India's incomplete actions in Jammu and Kashmir allowed. To appreciate the rapidity of its development, it should be noted that as late as 1959, when India had its first major clash with China, President Ayub Khan was also talking of repelling Chinese territorial incursions. Yet by early 1962, the two nations were discussing their de facto meeting point and Pakistan actually transferred Indian territory to China in 1963. At that time, it was a gold card member of two Western alliances –